Bradley Allen

Professor Imran Haider

Communication 218, CRN 59555

March 16, 2023

Emotional intelligence: A possible long-term solution to school shootings

Pandemic lockdowns, observed Boserup and colleagues (2020, p. 2753) in *The Journal of Emergency Medicine*, led to "alarming trends" of increased domestic violence. Studies have concluded that when children witnessed conflict at home they experienced increased anxiety, reduced social skills (Thompson & Trice-Black, 2012), and were prone to act aggressively themselves (Wahl & Metzner, 2012). When lockdowns lifted in 2022, and children went back to school, Americans witnessed the highest number of school shootings in the past five years (Blad et al., 2023). To date, much of the discussion around school shootings emphasizes gun control. However, the debate on gun control reaches back to the founding of the United States and has yet to be resolved (Longley, 2023). Given the duration of the debate and owing to the lack of agreement, Americans should look at other possible solutions to gun violence in schools. The best available evidence suggests that addressing school shootings requires an educational shift toward an emphasis on emotional intelligence during a critical period in childhood development: pre-k through 5th grade.

School shooters have commonalities beyond access to guns that deserve attention. The Violence Project, a non-profit, nonpartisan research center founded by psychologist Dr. Jillian Peterson, and sociologist Dr. James Densley, provides research and analysis on traits common to school shooters. *Key Findings* from The Violence Project (2022) showed that crisis conditions including anxiety, isolation, and depressed mood are predictive of gun violence in schools.

Additionally, 56% of school shooters have been bullied, and 62% show signs of mental health problems (The Violence Project, 2022). These behaviors are rooted in psychology, and they will only be resolved by addressing psychological wellbeing.

One way to address behaviors predictive of school shooters is through education with an emphasis on emotional intelligence. Emotional intelligence is the ability to understand and regulate emotions in self and others (Adler & Russell, 2016); it has been shown to promote elements of psychological wellbeing including self-esteem, life satisfaction, and self-acceptance (Carmeli et al., 2009). Other research found that individuals who accurately described their negative emotions developed better coping strategies (Barrett et al., 2001). Furthermore, emotional intelligence is key in promoting long-term relationships.

When couples perceived their emotional intelligence matched, they reported higher levels of relationship satisfaction (Smith et al., 2008). Sustaining those positive relationships increased lifespan and happiness (Mieo, 2017). The goal here is not to induce romantic relationships in childhood; instead, it is to provide children with the tools they need to cultivate positive relationships across the lifespan. Ideally, by age 18 (the average age of a school shooter), these relationships will reduce isolation, a feeling common among 39.5% of school shooters (The Violence Project, 2022). The evidence indicates that is the case. Emotional intelligence negatively correlates with many of the psychological traits of school shooters; that is, it promotes psychological wellbeing, helps individuals develop coping mechanisms for negative emotions, and increases relationship satisfaction, a key component of connectedness.

Research suggests that school connectedness reduces another predictor of gun violence: bullying. School connectedness is defined by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (2009, p.3) as a “belief by students that adults and peers in the school care about their learning as

well as about them as individuals." One study found that school connectedness reduced the negative effects of bullying (Carney et al., 2022). This is important because more than half of school shooters were bullied (The Violence Project, 2022). Given that relationships with peers and teachers are protective against bullying, a focus on emotional intelligence in schools should increase that protectivity. A reduction of bullying in schools should also reduce feelings of threat that contribute to anxiety. Fortunately, improving emotional intelligence is as easy as having conversation, but timing matters.

Asking questions during reading sessions in elementary school classrooms might be the single most important way to influence emotional intelligence. Researchers found that children who were questioned during reading sessions demonstrated improved vocabulary and reasoning skills (Hindman et al., 2019). As demonstrated by Barrett and colleagues (2001), when a person could accurately identify their emotions, they were able to develop better coping mechanisms. Learning emotional vocabulary would provide children with the tools they need to identify their emotions, allowing them to better cope with negative emotions. Interestingly, between two and six years old, a child's vocabulary was estimated to go from 500 words to 10,000 (Herschensohn, 2007). Given that vocabulary increased so dramatically at an early age, introducing emotional vocabulary in early childhood education will be most beneficial. But there is more to a conversation than vocabulary.

Conversations provide an opportunity to hone emotional intelligence and promote neurochemical responses shown to reduce depression. Researchers found that simply hearing a familiar, comforting voice, more than the content of a conversation, caused the release of a neurochemical, oxytocin (Seltzer et al., 2012). Oxytocin played a pivotal role in human bonding, and was found to reduce depression (Watson, 2021). Following reading sessions with peer

conversation should further increase peer bonding and connectivity while simultaneously decreasing depression, all of which may reduce the prevalence of school shootings later in life. Put simply, emotional intelligence gets to the root issue of school shootings.

In *Walden*, Henry David Thoreau (1910, p. 98) deduced "There are a thousand hacking at the branches of evil to one who is striking at the root." Thoreau's deduction is a fitting analogy for how the United States should respond to school violence: striking at the root, psychological wellbeing. While emotional intelligence does not provide an immediate solution, there are many reasons it is worth pursuing. First, it reduces behavior predictive of school shooters including anxiety, isolation, depressed mood, and bullying. Second, it has long-term potential. People who rate high in emotional intelligence live longer, happier lives. Third, it is simple to implement. In early childhood, educators simply need to read stories rich with emotional language and have conversations about those stories with their students. Fourth, emotional intelligence is a more agreeable solution. Increasing the level of control over guns is hotly debated, but very few would argue against increasing happiness. Finally, there is wisdom in pursuing emotional intelligence. Moving forward with an agreeable and beneficial long-term solution is better than stagnating in debate while lives are lost. If nothing changes, the latter is guaranteed.

References

Adler, R. B., & Russell, P. F. (2016). *Looking out, looking in* (15th ed.). Cengage Learning.

Barrett, L. F., Gross, J., Christensen, T., & Benvenuto, M. (2001). Knowing what you're feeling and knowing what to do about it: Mapping the relation between emotion differentiation and emotion regulation. *Cognition and Emotion,* 15, 713–724. https://doi.org/10.1080/02699930143000239

Blad, E., Baker, L., Hyon-Young, K., & Peele, H. (2023, January 27). School shootings in 2022: 4 key takeaways. *Education Week*. Retrieved March 7, 2023, from https://www.edweek.org/leadership/school-shootings-in-2022-4-key-takeaways/2022/12

Boserup, B., McKenney, M., & Elkbuli, A. (2020, December). Alarming trends in US domestic violence during the COVID-19 pandemic. *The American Journal of Emergency Medicine*, *28*(12), 2753-2755. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ajem.2020.04.077

Carmeli, A., Yitzhak-Halevy, M., & Weisberg, J. (2009, January 16). The relationship between emotional intelligence and psychological wellbeing. *Journal of Managerial Psychology*, *24*(1), 66-78. https://doi.org/10.1108/02683940910922546

Carney, J. V., Kim, J., Hyunhee, K., Guo, X. & Hazler, R. J. (2022). The role of school connectedness in mitigating the impact of victimization on life satisfaction. Professional School Counseling, 26(1), 1-10. https://doi.org/10.1177/2156759X221105463

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. (2009). *School connectedness: Strategies for increasing protective factors among youth*. U.S. Department of Health and Human Services. https://stacks.cdc.gov/view/cdc/5767

Herschensohn, J. R. (2007). *Language development and age*. Cambridge University Press. https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511486487

Hindman, A. H.; Wasik, B. A. & Bradley, D. E. (2019). How classroom conversations unfold: Exploring teacher-child exchanges during shared book reading. *Early Education and Development*, *30*(4), 478–495. https://doi.org/10.1080/10409289.2018.1556009

Longley, R. (2023, January 08). Timeline of gun control in the United States. *Thought Co.* Retrieved March 13, 2023, from https://www.thoughtco.com/us-gun-control-timeline-3963620

Mieo, L. (2017, April 11). *Good genes are nice, but joy is better*. The Harvard Gazette. Retrieved February 20, 2023, from https://news.harvard.edu/gazette/story/2017/04/over-nearly-80-years-harvard-study-has-been-showing-how-to-live-a-healthy-and-happy-life/

Seltzer, L., Prososki, A., Ziegler, T., & Pollak, S. (2012, January). Instant message vs. speech: Hormones and why we still need to hear each other. *Evolution and Human Behavior*, *33*(1), 42-45. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.evolhumbehav.2011.05.004

Smith, L., Heaven, P., & Ciarrochi, J. (2008, April). Trait emotional intelligence, conflict communication patterns, and relationship satisfaction. *Personality and Individual Differences*, *44*(6), 1314-1325. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2007.11.024

Thompson, E. H., & Trice-Black, S. (2012). School-based group interventions for children exposed to domestic violence. *Journal of Family Violence*, *27*, 233–241. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10896-012-9416-6

Thoreau, H. D. (1910). *Walden*. Thomas Y. Crowell & Company. Retrieved March 10, 2023, from https://books.google.com/books?id=yiQ3AAAAIAAJ

The Violence Project. (2022). *Key findings: Mass public shootings today are more frequent and deadlier*. Retrieved March 7, 2023, from https://www.theviolenceproject.org/key-findings/

Wahl, K., & Metzner, C. (2012). Parental influences on the prevalence and development of child aggressiveness. *Journal of Child & Family Studies*, *21*, 344–355. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10826-011-9484-x

Watson, S. (2021, July 20). Oxytocin: The love hormone. *Harvard Health Publishing*. Retrieved March 7, 2023, from https://www.health.harvard.edu/mind-and-mood/oxytocin-the-love-hormone